



Zero Tolerance

PATNA The past often is the prologue, as former Bihar transport minister Ramanand Prasad Singh, who had to quit a month after being inducted into Nitish Kumar's Cabinet, learnt the hard way. Singh had to resign after a vigilance commission case registered in 1990 for alleged irregularities in

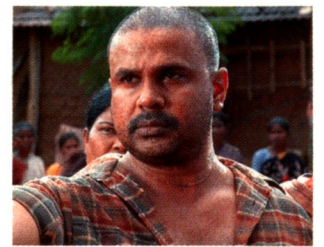
the purchase of hosepipes resurfaced. As a fuel technologist then, Singh had "recommended" the purchase of inferior items worth Rs 47,250. Another chargesheet was filed against him in 1991. The case has been pending in a trial court. Singh claimed he was innocent, maintaining that he

RESIGNED: Singh resigned "as a matter of propriety". However, the buzz in political circles is that he quit under duress following Kumar's zero-tolerance on tainted ministers.

In November 2005, Jeetan Ram Manjhi had to quit within hours of his induction because of pending corruption charges but was later reinducted after being absolved of the charges. While Singh may be hoping for something similar, his resignation has alarmed many in Bihar. State Excise and Prohibition Minister Jamshed Ashraf has surrendered and obtained bail in a model code violation case. Another minister, Bhagwan Singh Kushwaha, is under the scanner for being an accused in a case of massacre. **by Amitabh Srivastava**

Potboiler Script

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM The showdown could beat the script of a potboiler. All the stakeholders in the crisis-ridden Malayalam film industry are now engaged in an ugly war amongst themselves. The reason: the powerful lobby of Malayalam Cine Technicians' Association (MACTA), a union of directors and technicians, have decided not to work with



ROLE CALL: Dileep prominent actor Dileep (the successor to superstars Mammooty and Mohanlal). The decision was prompted by a complaint by director Thulasidas who claimed that Dileep had not honoured a contract signed by him four years ago to work in his next film, nor had he returned the Rs 4 lakh advance payment. Dileep allegedly opted out of Thulasidas' film because the director's latest movie, *College Kumaran* starring Mohanlal had bombed. The association of producers has jumped into the fray challenging MACTA's ban saying directors have no right to ban or engage artistes. MACTA president Vinayan has clarified that it had never called for a ban and had only forwarded the director's complaint to the Association of Malayalam Movie Actors. The audience eagerly awaits 'The End'. **by M.G.Radhakrishnan**

OBITUARY

NAMAS BHOJANI

He was one of India's greatest playwrights. Vijay Tendulkar, whose hard-hitting Marathi plays established him as an irreverent but brilliant writer of plays with contemporary, unconventional themes, passed away on May 19 in Pune. He was 80. Born in a Bhalavalikar Saraswat Brahmin family in Kolhapur, Tendulkar wrote his first play at the age of six. He quit his studies at 14 to participate in the freedom struggle, a move that alienated him from his family. Tendulkar started out writing for newspapers and his first play which was staged was *Grushastha* (Householder), though he had already written *Amchyavar Kon Prem Karnar* (Who Will Love Us). It was with *Shrimant* in 1956 that he made a name for himself in Marathi theatre. *Shrimant* revolved around an unmarried woman who decides to keep her child, even as the patriarch of the family tries to buy her a husband and save the family name. *Gidhade* (Vultures) in



Vijay Tendulkar
1928-2008

1961, *Shantata! Court Chalu Aahe* (Silence! The Court Is In Session) in 1967, *Sakharam Binder* and the much acclaimed *Ghasiram Kotwal* in 1972 were works that created a furore in the theatre world. Controversial and gut wrenching, Tendulkar removed the silken wraps covering the violence and politics that engulfed life by putting it on stage. He also wrote screen plays for 11 Hindi (*Nishant*, *Akrosh*, *Ardh Satya* among others) and seven Marathi films. In a career spanning nearly six decades, Tendulkar wrote 27 full length plays, 25 one act plays, 16 children's plays, a biography and several short stories. One of the strongest political voices, controversy followed Tendulkar throughout his career—several of his plays were banned while others provoked Brahmin and right wing groups to use violent means to stop performances.

by Nirmala Ravindran